Muhammad Usman Naeem

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Education

Tufts University — Medford, MA, USA
Ph.D., Economics & Public Policy — Expected 2027
Fields: Development; Environmental; Behavioural; Public

Lahore University of Management Sciences — Lahore, Pakistan
M.S., Economics — 2015

National University of Singapore — Singapore
B.A., Economics — 2009

Research Positions

Harvard University, Department of Economics — Cambridge, MA, USA
Visiting Fellow — Jan–Jun 2026

International Growth Centre — Pakistan
Country Economist — 2015–2021

References

Steve Cicala	**Kyle Emerick**	**Michael Greenstone**	**Frank Schilbach**
steve.cicala@tufts.edu	kyle.emerick@tufts.edu	mgreenst@uchicago.edu	fschilb@mit.edu

Job Market Paper

"The Idle Margin: Frictions in Everyday Conservation"

Abstract. This paper asks why privately and socially beneficial conservation fails when it must be repeated. I study vehicle idling—a ubiquitous but underexplored margin of vehicle use—using a randomised field experiment with 6,621 private vehicles in Pakistan whose GPS trackers report engine status, speed, and location every 10 seconds. The experiment separately varies private information, social-cost salience, financial rewards, and real-time in-car reminders. Baseline beliefs reveal widespread misperceptions about warm-up idling and the stop duration at which engine shutoff saves fuel or reduces environmental harm. Private information reduces idling at stops longer than 30 seconds by 1.8 minutes per observed vehicle-day, about 9 percent of the placebo mean. Adding social-cost information or payments produces little further reduction. Activating a real-time reminder instead attenuates the preceding no-reminder package. Heterogeneity and revealed-demand evidence point to self-monitoring crowdout, with external reminders substituting for drivers' own attention. The results identify private misperceptions as a binding friction and show that externally supplied attention can backfire when it displaces self-monitoring.

Working Papers

"Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

"Preaching Against Power Theft"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

"Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

Selected Work in Progress

"Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution"
with Steve Cicala and Kyle Emerick

"Making Pollution Visible: Emissions Disclosure"
with Michael Greenstone

Research Grants

Total funding as PI/Co-PI: over $1.1 million.

£57,463 (IGC); $8,125 (Weiss)	The Idle Margin: Frictions in Everyday Conservation
£277,762 (IGC)	Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing
$167,904 (Weiss; K-CAI); £64,097 (IGC)	Preaching Against Power Theft
£124,677 (IGC); $24,874 (Weiss)	Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement
£31,172 (IGC)	Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution
£66,272 (IGC)	Making Pollution Visible: Emissions Disclosure
$109,938 (ATAI; DERF); £24,919 (IGC)	Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning

Presentations

2022–2026 Harvard University, Development Advising Group; IGC–World Bank ieConnect Transport Roundtable (planned); Stanford University, Behavioral Public Economics Boot Camp; UC Berkeley, Environmental and Energy Economics Summer School; MIT, Behavioral Economics; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop

Teaching

Tufts University Medford, MA, USA

Teaching Assistant, Advanced Empirical Methods for Doctoral Students	2026–2027
Teaching Assistant, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (undergraduate)	2025–2026
Teaching Assistant, Behavioral Economics (graduate)	2023–2026